Group 5 — Inuit Nunangat First: sovereignty begins at home

Oct 29, 2026 · @Adam

Our position: Canada would not be an Arctic state without Inuit. Every other group in this room is debating what to do with a homeland that Inuit have occupied for thousands of years, and most of them have not asked. Canada's claim to the Passage rests on Inuit use of that ice. So the rule is simple: nothing about us without us. If Ottawa wants Inuit Nunangat to be Canada's shield, it has to make Inuit Nunangat part of Canada first: housing, water, food, a university, and a seat at the table where decisions are made.

Briefing

Inuit Nunangat, the Inuit homeland, covers about 40 per cent of Canada's land mass and most of its coastline. Four modern land-claim agreements recognize Inuit rights across it (ITK Poverty Reduction Strategy, June 2026). Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami (ITK), the national Inuit organization, has put its position bluntly: Inuit sovereignty *is* Canada's sovereignty, and the Arctic's critical minerals, energy and shipping routes all sit in Inuit Nunangat (ITK, An Inuit Vision for Arctic Sovereignty). ITK welcomes Canada's new attention to the North, but argues that the only long-term way to secure the Arctic is to close the gap between Inuit Nunangat and the rest of the country.

That gap is wide. Around 40 per cent of Inuit in Inuit Nunangat lived in overcrowded housing in 2021; in Nunavut, one-third of Inuit live in homes in poor repair against a national average of 7.4 per cent (CBC North; Maclean's, Sept. 2026). The CSIS liaison for Nunavut told a gathering of mayors that the infrastructure gap is itself a national security risk. Residents are split on the military build-up: some say it makes them feel protected, while others, like an Igloolik resident quoted by CBC, do not want a larger military presence and fear conflict.

The frustration boiled over in June 2026. After a two-day Arctic sovereignty conference in Ottawa, ITK president Natan Obed said Inuit take threats to Canadian sovereignty very seriously and want to be active players in defence, but warned that Ottawa was returning to a "territorial North" rather than an Inuit Nunangat North. ITK rejected what it called outdated, colonial approaches, and Obed said that if the relationship with Ottawa sours,

Inuit could look to foreign partners, though they would talk to Canada first (CBC, June 19, 2026; Global News, June 2026). The federal government replied that Inuit are essential partners and that meaningful engagement with rights-holders is fundamental.

Inuit are also organizing across borders. In July 2026, the Inuit Circumpolar Council assembly in Iqaluit, with delegates from Canada, Greenland, Alaska and Russia, agreed to focus on peace and stability in the Arctic and protection of the Inuit way of life, and acclaimed Nunavut's Aluki Kotierk as international chair (ITK, July 27, 2026). Obed has said that no other nation-state can tell Inuit how to hold sovereignty over their homeland; Inuit have been doing it for 200 years (ITK, May 2026).

> "My grandfather's family was moved to Resolute in 1953 so Canada could say someone lived there. Now the government wants a base in Resolute. This time they will ask us, or they will not build it." — *Leah Qanatsiaq, hunter and hamlet councillor, Pond Inlet* **[illustrative]**

Quotations marked [illustrative] are fictional composite voices written for readability. Real public figures are paraphrased from the linked reports.